

THE BEAUTIFUL AUDITION

While the world's biggest stars dominated the headlines, a clutch of **emerging talents** used the FIFA World Cup to boost their reputations, attract Europe's elite clubs and reshape the transfer market.

Anish Pathiyil
anish.p@thehindu.co.in

The FIFA World Cup is often branded as a football carnival. For a month and a bit, there is no sporting event that can rival the popularity the tournament enjoys.

The 2026 edition saw global superstars perform in front of millions of eager viewers. But amid the celebrations of these heroes, a few unheralded players quietly put in performances that saw them deservedly share the limelight.

It is not just the ardent, sleep-deprived fans these players

have impressed. Showing your pedigree in a high-pressure environment like the FIFA World Cup is often a key differentiating factor for clubs looking to strengthen their squads.

Scouts and sporting directors would have drawn up prospective shopping lists ahead of the tournament, and some of these players have surely forced a few additions.

Promise to performance

There has already been movement in the transfer market involving some of these stars. Freiburg's Johan Manzambi looked set to join Newcastle United but has since

Breaking new ground: Aston Villa has completed the signing of midfielder Johan Manzambi from Freiburg for a club record fee of just over £50m. GETTY

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